Formulating a good research question

by Briane Paul V. Samson, PhD

What is a **research question**?

Research question

It is what a study or research tries to answer.

Often rooted on a problem, a new or understudied phenomena, or a technical challenge known in the field.

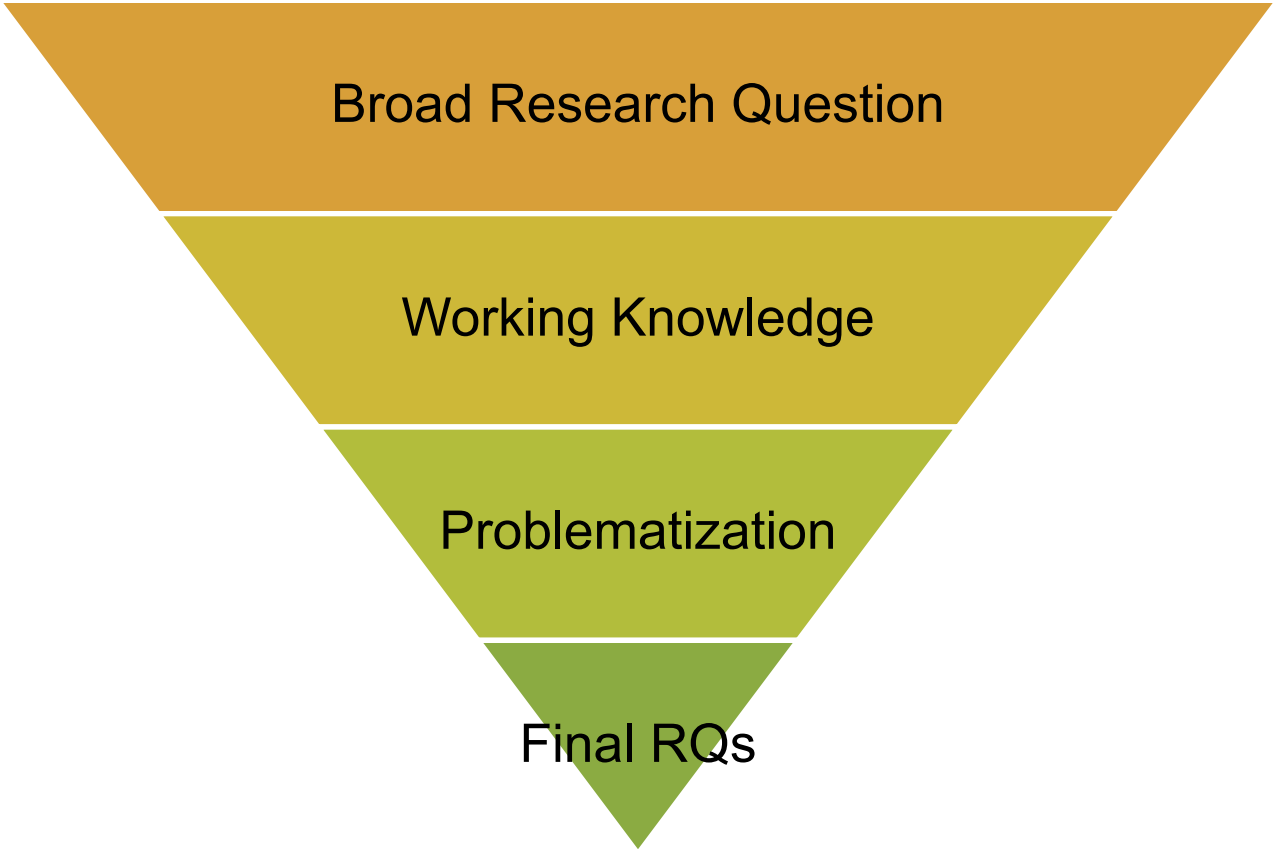
Typically answered in a study's conclusion.

Characteristics

RQs are **dynamic**

Refined through review of literature or new theories/framework

A single but large study can have more than one (1) RQ


Broad Research Question
Working Knowledge
Problematization
Final RQs

Broad Research Question

How do we reduce traffic congestion?

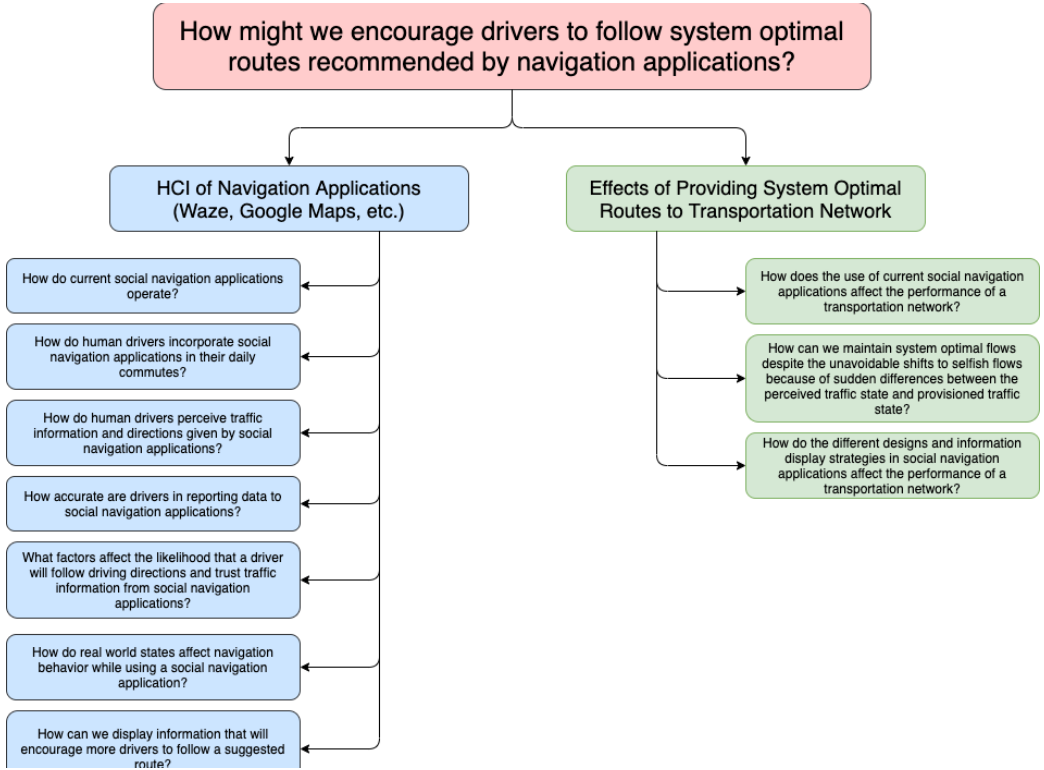
Working Knowledge

- What are currently used to manage traffic congestion?
- What do drivers use?
- What are navigation applications?
- How do they work?
- What are their assumptions?
    - Drivers always want the fastest route to their destination

Working Questions

- Drivers don’t always choose the shortest path
  - Some drivers choose a path with the least delays (e.g. least traffic light stops)
- Drivers don’t always follow the recommendations
  - They change when road signs are unclear, no parking space, etc.
- Why do some drivers not follow route recommendations? Is it the same behavior for all types of navigation applications?

Research Question(s)



What is a good research question?

FINER

Is it **F**easible?

Is it **I**nteresting?

Is it **N**ovel?

Is it **E**thical?

Is it **R**elevant?

Hulley SB, Cummings SR, Browner WS, Grady DG, Newman TB. Designing Clinical Research. Lippincott Williams & Wilkins; 2007.

How good?

How does social media affect people’s behavior?

How good?

How does social media affect people's behavior?

Better: What effect does the daily use of YouTube have on the attention span of children aged under 16?

How good?

How might we improve learning management systems?

How good?

How might we improve learning management systems?

Better: ???

Questions?